

afford a better home and had decided to take the plunge and buy in the area where other, older members of the firm lived. They lacked the funds for the total down payment, but Allen arranged an advance on his bonus to close on the house.

When they moved, Sherry purchased custom curtains, drapes, and wall decorations with Allen's encouragement. He said (and believed) that what they were doing was in the best interest of his career. Before they were finished decorating and paying for moving costs, their bills totaled nearly \$25,000.

By that time Sherry was beginning to feel a little nervous about their spending, particularly since they didn't have the money to pay for all their expenses. Allen told her not to worry, because the sale of their first home would net enough to pay back the advance and the improvements to the new home. Indeed, they did have a contract on their first home that would net them a profit. Unfortunately, the contract had an "if" clause in it, which meant that the buyers were obligated only if their home sold. So Allen and Sherry bought a new home, along with all the trappings, based on the contingent sale of their old home, which was dependent upon the sale of the buyers' home (a lot of ifs). It's obvious that no one had ever explained to them the principle, "Do not boast about tomorrow, for you do not know what a day may bring forth" (Proverbs 27:1).

As you probably have guessed, the sale of the buyers' home fell through, so they backed out of the purchase of Allen and Sherry's home. Allen and Sherry were already making payments on the new home, and they were continuing payments on their old home as well. To say the least, Sherry was uneasy about their situation. Each month they fell further behind, and still their house didn't sell. She wanted to lower the asking price, but Allen didn't agree, stating that it was worth what they were asking.

Finally, after six months, they had an offer on the house, though it was for many thousands of dollars less than the original contract. By that time Allen was glad to sell; they faced a higher mountain of unpaid bills each month. Virtually all the profit they made on the